FREE BREAKDOWN

The 8 Roles Every Startup Needs — And What Each One Actually Costs You

A founder's honest breakdown of the team every company eventually needs, what each role really costs to hire, and where the biggest opportunities are to run leaner without running worse.

INTRODUCTION

Before you hire anyone, know what you're actually hiring for.

Every company — whether it's a two-person startup or a scaling small business — eventually needs the same eight functions covered. Not necessarily eight people. Eight *functions*.

Most founders learn this the expensive way: by hiring too early for a role they didn't need yet, or waiting too long on a role that was quietly costing them customers and revenue the whole time.

This breakdown lays out each of the eight roles plainly — what it actually covers day to day, and what it typically costs at a junior-to-mid market rate. Treat it as a reference for planning your own team, your own budget, and your own priorities.

HOW TO USE THIS

Read through all eight. For each one, ask yourself: is this role actively costing me money or customers right now by being unfilled? Or is this a role I can delay, combine with another, or handle differently for now? That one question will tell you more about your next hire than any org chart.

THE BREAKDOWN

Roles 1–4

1. Founder / CEO

Typical cost: often unpaid or below-market early on, true value $150K+/yr

Owns strategy, fundraising, and the key relationships that keep the company alive — investors, early customers, critical partners. This role sets direction; everyone else executes against it. In the earliest days, this is rarely a "hire" — it's the founder absorbing the role directly.

2. CTO / Lead Developer

Typical cost: $130K–$180K+/yr, or $40K+ as a fractional/part-time lead

Owns the technical architecture, code quality standards, and engineering hiring. Often still writing code directly — roughly half their time in an early-stage company — while also making the calls that prevent expensive technical mistakes down the line.

3. Full-Stack Developer(s)

Typical cost: $35K–$110K+/yr per developer, depending on seniority and location

The people actually building the product. At early stage, these are generalists — comfortable moving across frontend, backend, and basic DevOps as needed, rather than narrow specialists. Most startups need one to three of these before they need anything more senior.

4. Product Manager

Typical cost: $90K–$140K+/yr, or absorbed by founder/co-founder early on

Decides what actually gets built next. Talks to customers, prioritizes the roadmap, and translates "what users want" into "what engineering builds." In very early-stage companies, this is almost always the CEO or a co-founder wearing a second hat.

Roles 5–8

5. Sales / Business Development

Typical cost: $70K–$120K+/yr base, often plus commission

Lands the initial customers, closes deals, and manages the relationships that turn into renewals. In the earliest stage, this is almost always founder-led — nobody can sell the vision like the person who built it.

6. Customer Success / Support

Typical cost: $45K–$75K+/yr, often part-time initially

Handles onboarding, answers support tickets, and gathers the feedback that shapes the next roadmap decision. Frequently combined with sales in the early days — the same person who closed the deal is often the one making sure the customer actually succeeds with the product.

7. Finance / Operations

Typical cost: $60K–$100K+/yr, or $500–$3K/mo fractional

Covers bookkeeping, HR basics, admin, and legal/compliance housekeeping. One of the most commonly outsourced roles — a fractional CFO or bookkeeper can often cover this more cost-effectively than a full-time hire, especially pre-scale.

8. Marketing

Typical cost: $55K–$95K+/yr, or $3K–$8K+/mo for an agency retainer

Content, social presence, and brand messaging — making sure the right people even find out the company exists. Often the most neglected role early on, usually run at a fraction of a full-time load or folded into product or sales until there's budget to dedicate to it properly.

THE REAL NUMBER

What a full team actually costs, stacked up.

Here's the range, using conservative junior-to-mid market estimates across all eight functions:

Founder / CEO (opportunity cost)	**$0 – $150K+**
CTO / Lead Developer	**$40K – $180K**
Full-Stack Developer(s)	**$35K – $110K**
Product Manager	**$0 – $140K**
Sales / Business Development	**$0 – $120K**
Customer Success / Support	**$0 – $75K**
Finance / Operations	**$6K – $100K**
Marketing	**$36K – $95K**
Estimated full-team range	**$117K – $970K+/yr**

THE TAKEAWAY

Most early-stage companies aren't underfunded because the idea is bad. They're underfunded because the cost of covering all eight functions properly is simply higher than the runway allows. That gap — between what needs to get done and what you can afford to pay people to do it — is exactly where leaner, smarter systems earn their keep.

If you want to see how I closed that gap in my own company — and the system I built to cover these roles without the full payroll — the full story is one click away.